Prabhakaran’s decision to assign a woman to retaliate against Rajiv Gandhi because the IPKF had perpetuated many atrocities on women. Sivarasan, Murugan and Shubha sought Lord Venkateshwara’s blessings for their safe return to Sri Lanka.

Knowing the situation would eventually turn against them, Sivarasan advised Nalini to cross over to Sri Lanka with Murugan. But she turned down the idea. The couple went back to Tirupati even as Murugan got his head tonsured to honour his vow to kill Rajiv.

Anirudhya was back in office after eight days. He wanted to debrief his editors on his investigation in Madras. But all of them seemed busy. And Shekhar Gupta was off to Colombo. Dilip Bobb called him on the intercom and asked him how it had gone in Madras. Anirudhya started narrating what he had uncovered so far. ‘Just write down everything,’ Bobb said.

By the time he finished writing down ‘everything’, it was four in the morning. The only break Anirudhya took in between was to briefly speak to his wife on the phone twice. He sent the story to Bobb and Inderjit Badhwar through the office system and left for home.

The next day, he didn’t hear anything from either Badhwar or Bobb. He hung around their cabins, but there was nothing. Senior cameraman Pramod Pushkarna stopped by at his desk in between asking him if he needed any photographs for his Madras assignment. Anirudhya said he was waiting to hear back from the editors. Pushkarna wished him luck and left.

Anirudhya could not wait any longer. He checked with Harpal, who coordinated copies for the entire editorial department about what was happening to his story.

Harpal spoke without raising his head, ‘No idea. Have you checked with Dilip?’

‘Not yet.’

‘Inder?’

‘Nope.’